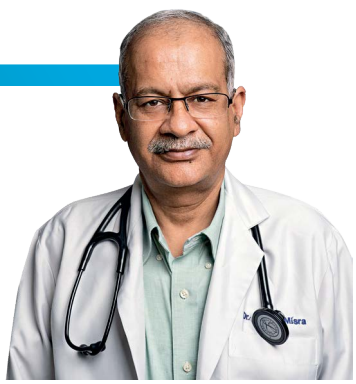
all over the world, including in India," says Dr Srinivasa P. Munigoti, consultant, endocrinology, Fortis Hospital, Bannerghatta Road, Bengaluru. From Oprah Winfrey to Elon Musk, tech moguls to TikTok influencers, all manner of celebrities started swearing by Wegovy, sparking a shortage that began depriving people who actually *needed* the medication. It was exactly the point Eli Lilly, makers of Ozempic's closest rivals, Mounjaro and Zepbound, made in a commercial released a day before Oscar night, castigating their drugs' vanity use by Hollywood A-listers so that they could fit into a dress or a tux.

The craze reached Indian shores, too, its prohibitive cost no deterrent to desi determination to lay their hands on a skinny pen, as the semaglutide injections are called, so that they could look their best for a wedding or an awards



"I DO NOT SEE SEMAGLUTIDE BECOMING THE FIRST LINE OF TREATMENT FOR DIABETICS IN INDIA. ONE, THE COST IS TOO HIGH; TWO, INDIAN DIABETICS ARE NOT AS OBESE AS WESTERN ONES"

DR ANOOP MISHRA
Director, National Diabetes Obesity Cholesterol Foundation

function. India's weight management market was Rs 1.72 lakh crore in 2022, as the findings of a study by the market research company IMARC Group revealed, and is projected to touch Rs 3.14 lakh crore by 2028. But since the launch of Rybelsus, India's weight loss market has already triple to nearly triple in size to Rs 4.74 lakh crore, according to figures from Pharmarack, a commerce to insights technology company.

So, is semaglutide the unmitigated blessing it is being hailed as? Dr Anoop Mishra, director of the National Diabetes Obesity Cholesterol Foundation, and chairman, Fortis C-DOC Centre of Excellence for Diabetes, does not think so. "Semaglutide has weight loss and diabetes control benefits," he says, "but I do not see it becoming the first line of treatment for diabetics in India for two reasons. One, the cost is too high; two, Indian diabetics are not as obese as those in the West. There is no data yet to show how this drug benefits weight loss in those with BMI under 30"—that is, the average Indian type.

Their cost is indeed an inhibiting factor, with Ozempic costing $936 (approx. Rs 77,461) and Wegovy $1,300 (Rs 1.07 lakh) per month in the US and a 10-tablet strip of Rybelsus setting you back by more than Rs 3,000 in India. Their soaring demand has led to shortages and the shortages to the rise of counterfeits and unauthorised drugs. Like all drugs, semaglutide is not without its side-effects either. These range from moderate gastro-intestinal symptoms like nausea and vomiting to more serious outcomes like stomach paralysis and even cancer. There is also no significant data yet on the long-term impact of the drug, or from trials in Indian clinical settings.

But the lack of data cannot be enough reason to dismiss agonists, drugs that bind to receptors in particular cells in the body like a naturally-occurring hormone would, as the most radical treatment for diabesity (diabetes + obesity) and CVD. Pharma firms are exploring their potential for a range

THE WOR

A few incretin mimetics

OZEMPIC

Active ingredient: Semaglutide (GLP-1 agonist)

Manufactured by: Nova Nordisk

Form and frequency: 2 mg weekly injectable

Approved for what and when: For treatment of Type 2 diabetes in the US in 2017

Cost: $936 (Rs 77,600 approx.) a month. Not yet available in India

WEGOVY

Active ingredient: Semaglutide (GLP-1 agonist)

Manufactured by: Nova Nordisk

Form and frequency: 2.4 mg injectable to be used weekly

Approved for what and when: For chronic weight loss in 2021 and for heart health improvement in 2024, only in the US

Cost: $1,300 (Rs 1.08 lakh approx.) for a four-week supply. Not yet available in India

RYBELSUS

Active ingredient: Semaglutide (GLP-1 agonist)

Manufactured by: Nova Nordisk

Form and frequency: 3 mg, 7 mg, 14 mg oral tablets to be taken daily

Approved for what and when: For Type 2 diabetes in the US in 2019. Got CDSCO approval for clinical trials in 2020, launched in India in January 2022

Cost: 10-strip tablet for Rs 3,170 (3 mg), Rs 3,520 (7 mg) and Rs 3,870 (14 mg)

MOUNJARO

Active ingredient: Tirzepatide (GIP and GLP-1 agonist)

Manufactured by: Eli Lilly

Form and frequency: Weekly injectable with a starting dose of 2.5 mg